



Beyond The Hype

The conflict that began on February 28 after the coordinated US and Israeli air strikes on Iran was a wake-up call for India and the world. The subsequent blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has led to a massive oil and gas supply shortage and continuing volatility in prices. Several lessons have been learnt from the crisis, with the most critical being the importance of building an economy that is self-reliant and businesses that are sustainable.

Like last year, *Business Today's* India's Most Sustainable Companies 2026 list recognises firms that have shown that sustainability can be integrated into core business strategy. The awards evaluation considered over 1,000 listed companies from over a dozen sectors, including oil and gas, automobiles, cement, banking and infrastructure, among others. The winners were chosen by a stellar jury from a list of 255 companies that made the final cut.

In the lead essay, *Richa Sharma* explores how India is balancing immediate energy needs with long-term climate commitments. In light of the West Asia conflict, coal gasification is being projected as a bridge to maintain grid resilience, even as renewable energy capacity expands. In an interview, Amarjeet Singh, whole-time member of the Securities and Exchange Board of India and the architect of the Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reporting framework, captures it pithily saying that climate and sustainability-related risks are increasingly translating into economic and financial risks, affecting business models, asset valuations and long-term growth prospects.

Energy transition challenges extend beyond fuel choices. *Karan Dhar* reports on India's push to increase ethanol blending in petrol, aimed at reducing imports and supporting farmers. However, higher blends like E85 and E100 can affect vehicles not designed for them and strain supplies of maize, a critical crop for ethanol production and much more. In another piece on ethanol, *Prasanna Mohanty* questions the sustainability of the biofuel, warning that widespread adoption may impact cropping patterns and potentially create food security risks.

Elsewhere, *Surabhi* examines the cost of air pollution and warnings from former IMF Chief Economist Gita Gopinath that chronic pollution poses a greater economic risk than tariffs or trade barriers.

Financial sustainability is equally critical. *Surabhi* and *Nachiket Kelkar* analyse the paradox of record gross foreign direct investment in 2026 alongside weak net inflows.

Together, this edition seeks to capture the multi-dimensional nature of sustainability. Energy security, alternative fuels, air quality, and investment are all intertwined in the quest for a sustainable growth story.

The winners this year demonstrate that sustainability is not just hype.

Looking ahead, the path is clear: resilience and sustainability must guide every policymaker and every company board's decision-making, to ensure that India builds a stronger, greener, and more equitable future. **BT**

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